MAKING COMMONS DYNAMIC · FIELD WORKSHOP, SYLHET · NOVEMBER 2026

Tanguar Haor: a field reflection

What three days of theory and one day in the haor changed

in what we notice, and in what we can now ask

Group presentation by seven members, Speakers 1 to 7

Field site: Joypur and the Tanguar Haor waterbody, Tahirpur, Sunamganj

Field day: 8 November 2026. Presented: 9 November 2026

A note on what this is

This is a reflection, not a survey, a diagnosis or a plan. One visit, a small number of voices, and most of what we say is attributed to the person who said it. Where we are reading rather than reporting, we say so on the slide.

HOW WE APPROACHED THIS REFLECTION

Four moves, repeated for each question

The same discipline for all six official questions, so that evidence and interpretation stay visibly apart.

BEFORE

What we took for granted walking in. Where we have no record of a prior group assumption, we label it an analytical starting point rather than claim it was our belief.

FIELD

One concrete episode or attributed statement, with its timestamp, kept in its own context rather than flattened into a generalisation.

THEORY

One or two taught ideas, used as the workshop defined them. Not every concept is forced into every question.

SHIFT and OPEN

What became less certain once field and theory were put together, and the sharper question we can now ask. For whom, when, where, at what level.

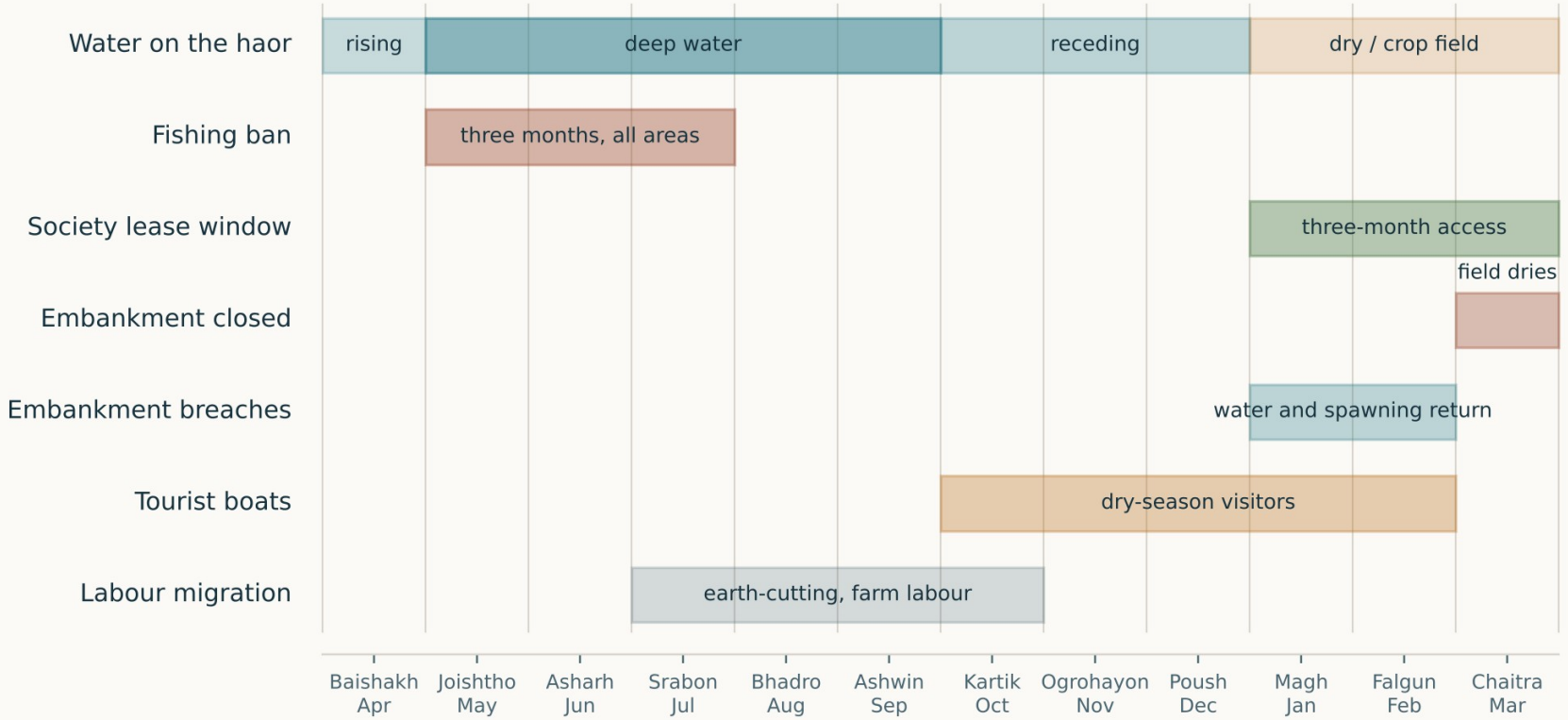
What our evidence tags mean

OBSERVED BY US | COMMUNITY TESTIMONY | PROFESSIONAL KII | WORKSHOP LECTURE | OUR READING | OPEN QUESTION

Quotation marks appear only where a primary transcript contains those words. Bengali speech is given in the original and then lightly translated, with its timestamp. A paraphrase never appears in quotation marks, and nothing our own group said in discussion is presented as something a community member said.

The same place is a different resource in every season

One year on the haor, as described to us: the same place is several resources in turn



All bands are as reported by participants in the Joypur community interview and the CNRS key-informant notes. Month edges are approximate, not measured.

COMMUNITY TESTIMONY · PROFESSIONAL KII

Joypur interview 00:03:27, 00:12:17-00:13:52, 00:29:00, 00:50:43 · CNRS KII Part 01

Excludability and subtractability do not hold still either

FOUR ATTRIBUTES WE COULD ACTUALLY POINT TO

Emergence and submergence. Water arrives, the fishery exists; water leaves, the field exists.

Access changes with the season, not with status. Fishing access is tied to a lease window; outside it, participants described fishing anyway.

Subtractability rises as the water falls. As depth drops, the same catch is taken from less space.

Exclusion is costly and partial. Of roughly fifty short machines, participants said two are caught.

WHAT SHIFTED FOR US

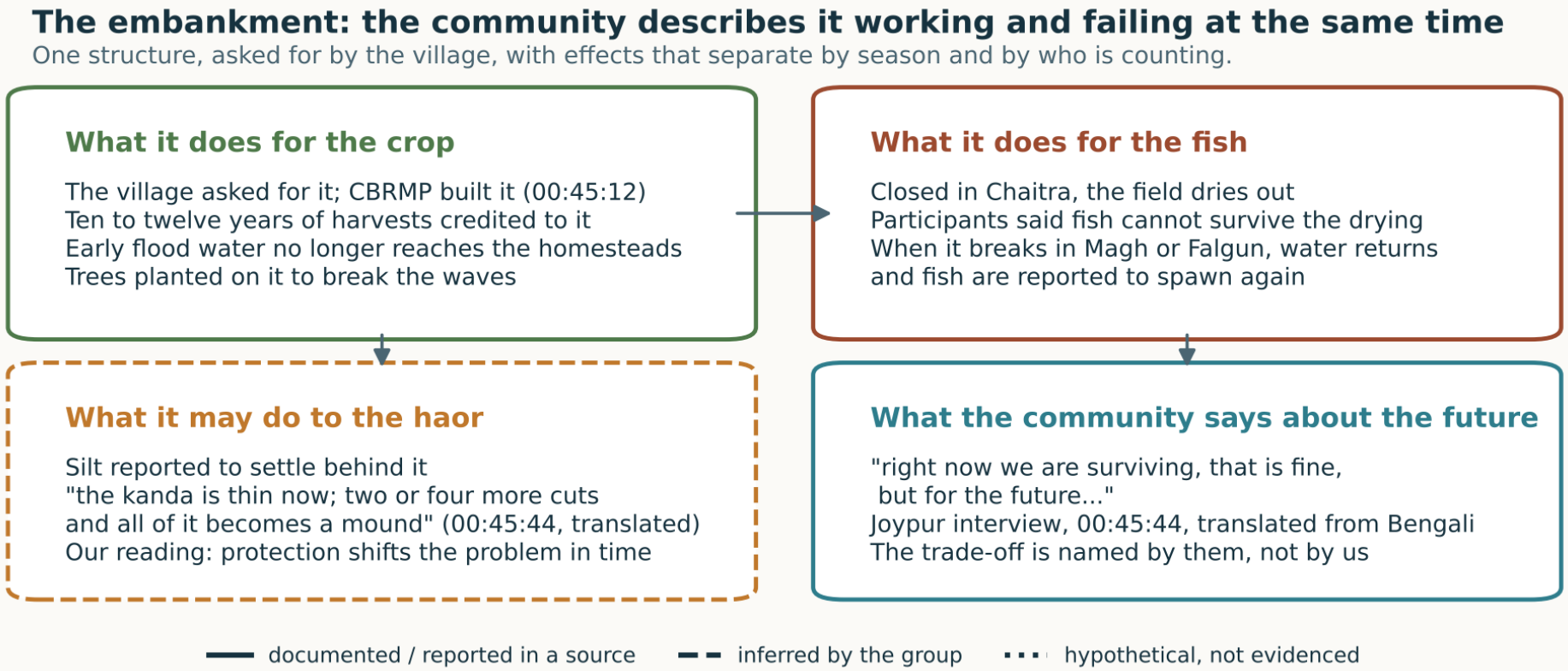
> *আগে তো ইজারাদার যখন আছিল তখন তো ইজারাদার শাসন দিয়া রাখছে, মাছ মারতে পারছে না।*
>
> *"when the lessee was here, the lessee kept order, people could not take fish."*
>
> Joypur community interview, 00:27:21. Translated from Bengali; lightly translated.

We arrived expecting the ephemeral quality to be mainly hydrological. The same speaker who described the lease era as better for fish then said the present arrangement suits him. Who may take what, and who enforces it, has changed at least three times in living memory.

Open question. If the resource dissolves every year, what is the right unit of a rule: the season, the water body, or the household that moves between both?

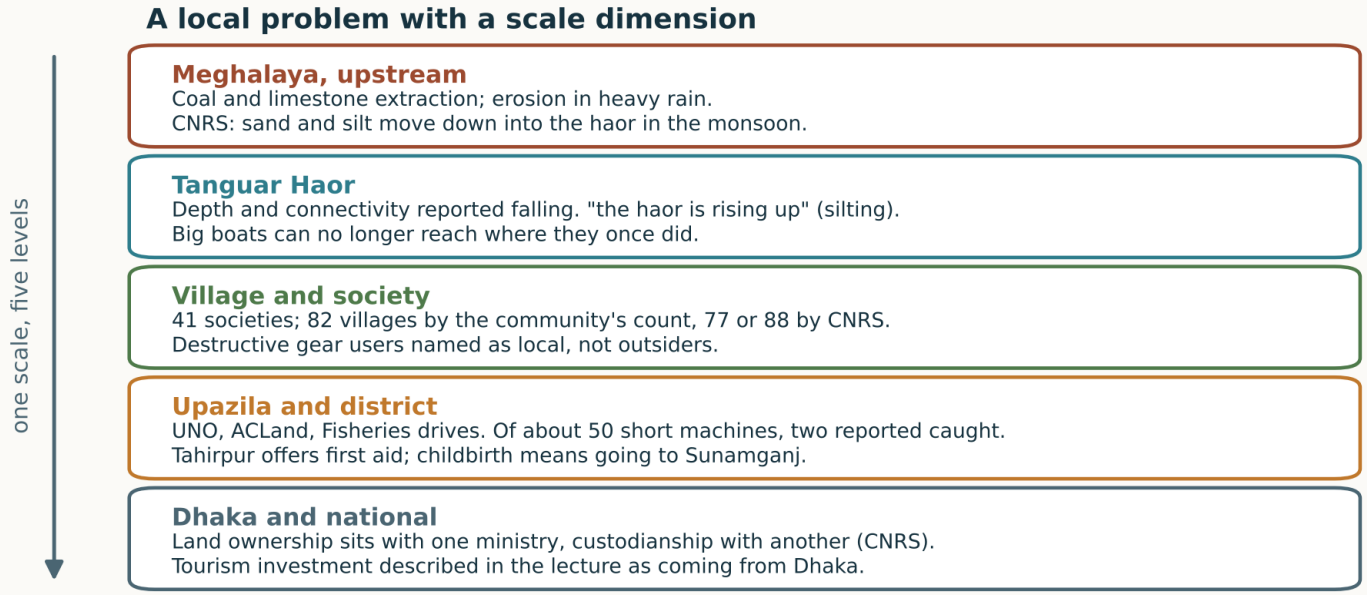
COMMUNITY TESTIMONY | WORKSHOP LECTURE | OPEN QUESTION

One structure, two opposite effects, both named by the same people



COMMUNITY TESTIMONY OUR READING Joypur interview 00:03:27, 00:04:42, 00:05:09, 00:31:26-00:32:53, 00:45:12-00:45:44

The problem does not sit at one level, and the blame does not sit outside



"what we might think is a local problem is actually an interconnected problem" - Prof. Prateep Nayak, lecture 00:14:27

A DISAGREEMENT WE ARE KEEPING

> *কারেন্ট জালে মাছ ধ্বংস করে না।*
>
> *"the current net does not destroy fish"*
>
> Joypur, 00:11:44. The speaker has used it since birth, to eat. He named the short machine and the kona jal as the destroyers; another speaker named the china duari.

We expected outsiders. We were told the opposite.

> *না এইখানের মানুষ, এই টাঙ্গুয়ারেরই মানুষ।*
>
> *"no, people from here, people of this very Tanguar"*
>
> Joypur, 00:49:37, asked who uses the shortgun and kona jal.

Open question. Which gear actually destroys what, and who is entitled to decide that when the people fishing disagree with each other?

COMMUNITY TESTIMONY | PROFESSIONAL KII | WORKSHOP LECTURE

Food and income: the exposure is seasonal, not general

WHAT WAS DESCRIBED TO US

— Catch described as half a kilo or very little now, where it used to be plentiful.

— Travelling to the town market costs 200 to 250 taka and two hours, so a small catch cannot cover the fare. Buyers, called nekari, come to the village instead.

— Paddy is kept for the household through the year, not sold.

— Rice stored in empty fish-feed sacks. Our group read this as preparing for scarcity; the storage we saw, the reason we inferred.

— Dried fish sells at 250 taka locally against 300 in the market, because the trip costs 300 to 500 taka.

WHY THIS IS AN EPHEMERAL-COMMONS VULNERABILITY

The income is not low in a steady way. It is concentrated into a window and then absent. A household that fishes for three months, grows paddy for three, and looks for other work for the rest is carrying the variability of the resource in its own calendar.

Professor Nayak's 6 November slides put it as a lack of access to capital assets, and as the absence of wellbeing in its material, relational and subjective dimensions. What we saw fits the material dimension. We have almost nothing on the other two.

> *তারা অশিক্ষিত মানুষ তারা কয় আমরা খাইয়া বাঁচি।*
>
> *"they are uneducated people, they say we live by eating"*
>
> Joypur, 00:33:00, on why telling people not to fish does not work. The CNRS informant made the same point independently.

COMMUNITY TESTIMONY | OUR READING | PROFESSIONAL KII

The thing that holds people here is the thing that exposes them

> *"When we asked him, you fish for three months, what do you do for the next three? We grow paddy. And the next three? We steal, we drive a rickshaw, we do this and that."*
>
> Our own group discussion, 00:10:45. This is a team member recalling the exchange, not a verbatim community quotation. The community transcript does describe fishing without permission at 00:28:33, using the same word.

What we did with that

Our group's first instinct, in the recording, was to call the three-month lease their lure, almost a weakness. Putting it next to the lecture changed that for us. The window is not a temptation. It is the only period in which the commons exists as a fishery they can legally enter, and it is three months out of twelve.

Set against the other numbers we were given, the exposure is easier to see: a three-month ban with compensation rice described as given "once, maybe two years"; electricity for about eight hours in twenty-four; the monthly family-card allowance that, in this settlement, nobody had received.

FOUR REPORTED FIGURES

3 months
of legal fishing access, by lease

3 months
of fishing ban, reported everywhere

8 hours
of electricity in 24, at present

0
households here reported to have received the family-card allowance

OUR READING · COMMUNITY TESTIMONY

Joypur 00:50:30, 00:54:51, 00:55:09 · group discussion 00:10:23-00:10:54

Provision exists. Use is another question.

Provision is not the same as use: four services as described to us

SERVICE	WHAT EXISTS	WHAT PEOPLE REPORTED DOING	WHAT STAYS OPEN
Drinking water	Three tubewells reported out of order; one submersible serves the kanda, 20 taka a month	Piped water for drinking and cooking, not bathing. River water preferred: "the tubewell water has no taste"	Is the water people actually drink safe? We did not test it, and nobody we met had
Primary schooling	One school, reached by crossing three rivers	Distance unresolved: the direct interview says about 1 km, twice; our group discussion said 4 km	A madrasa was set up locally. Prof. Nayak read it as possible self-organization, not as a system
Health care	Tahirpur described as first aid only; Sunamganj for childbirth	"in the monsoon it is death" - travel by hand-rowed boat. A maternal death in transport is a second-hand account	Paracetamol and antacid at home. When illness stops movement, income stops too
Shelter	Tin houses; one brick house with a tin roof observed	No windbreak: wind comes off the hills across open water onto the kanda and lifts the roofs	The only possible storm shelter is the school across three rivers. Stored rice read by us as preparing for scarcity

Sources: Joypur community interview (time-coded) and our own group discussion. Nothing in the third or fourth column was measured by us.

COMMUNITY TESTIMONY · OUR READING · WORKSHOP LECTURE

Joypur 00:16:28, 00:17:19-00:18:29, 00:38:38, 00:46:11 · group discussion 00:03:34-00:09:47

One number we will not quietly choose for you

How far is the school?

The direct interview, twice. “it would be one kilometre. When we go, we have to cross three rivers” (00:16:28), and again “one kilometre away” (00:46:16).

Our own group discussion. “it is four kilometres away, they said you have to cross three rivers” (00:04:01) — while another member had just said they did not hear the distance.

What we are doing with it. Reporting both, and treating the three river crossings, which every account agrees on, as the finding. The kilometre figure is not ours to settle.

FOUR MORE THINGS WE COULD NOT SETTLE

— How many villages. The community said 82; CNRS said 77, then accepted the IUCN plan's 88.

— Whether the drinking water is safe. Untested by us and, as far as we were told, by anyone here.

— Whether cultural practice has declined. Our group asserted it had, then noticed, on tape, that we never asked (00:13:04).

— Whether the maternal death and the 2022 displacement happened as relayed. Both reached us second hand through our own discussion.

OPEN QUESTION OUR READING

Open question: when a household's account and our notes disagree, whose record becomes the data?

Custody and ownership are not in the same hands

Who is responding, and how visible is it?

Community

- 41 societies registered to hold the lease
- Disputes settled by matbor and elders, not by the society
- A madrasa established locally
- Representatives bring in gear offenders
- Three villages said to run a lottery for tourist-boat turns

Government

- Three-month ban, reported as everywhere
- ACLand and UNO announce it; notice, not reasons
- Fisher cards, free, through the society
- Ban rice given "once, maybe two years"
- Family card: "not one person here has got it"

Civil society and projects

- CBSMTHP 2006-2018, in four phases
- USAID-funded activity ended March 2024
- Now: baseline, fish-catch monitoring, tourism carrying capacity
- Re-excavation and a fish pass planned
- Alternative income for about 400 households

Everything here is a reported strategy, not an assessed outcome. Figures such as 41 societies, 82 villages and the 24/76 revenue split are participant reports, not audited accounts.

To confirm before we present. The announced allocation gives Q1 one speaker, Q2 one, Q3 two, Q5 two and Q6 one. Question 4 has no assigned presenter. This bridge is our proposal, not an instruction from the group.

COMMUNITY TESTIMONY | PROFESSIONAL KII | OPEN QUESTION

We can evidence coping. We cannot evidence a transition.

Coping, adapting, or transitioning? Where our evidence actually sits

Coping

- Rice stored in fish-feed sacks
- Potatoes when fish are scarce
- Paracetamol and antacid at home
- Selling to the nekari in the village
- Moving to Netrokona in the 2022 flood

Well evidenced

Adaptive response

- Small-boat hire, 20 to 50 taka a head
- Lease, then paddy, then other work
- Seasonal labour to Tangail and Sylhet
- A locally established madrasa
- NGO loans taken in women's names

Evidenced, durability unknown

Viable transition

- Would need income across the year
- Would need the fish stock to recover
- Would need the card to reach the person
- We saw none of this established
- Boatman: "no, it does not last the year"

Not established by our evidence

The three columns are a reading of our own material against the vulnerability-to-viability framing, not a measured trajectory. Nothing we gathered lets us say a transition has happened.

documented / reported in a source · inferred by the group · hypothetical, not evidenced

COMMUNITY TESTIMONY · OUR READING · WORKSHOP LECTURE

Joypur 00:38:06, 00:43:01, 00:58:36 · boatman notes 18:56-20:11 · CNRS KII Part 02

We went in with a hypothesis about tourism. It was refused.

THE EXCHANGE

> *Interviewer: "big boats break the bank a lot … so the houseboats harm you."*
>
> Joypur, 00:58:09-00:58:15. Our side of the exchange.

> *না হাউসবোট থেইকা স্থবিধা তো আমরা একটা পাইতাছি … আমি তো নগদ লাভ দেখতাছি।*
>
> *"no, we are getting a benefit from the houseboats … I am seeing cash profit"*
>
> Joypur, 00:58:24. Translated from Bengali; lightly translated.

He had already said, at 00:47:12, that houseboat noise does not harm fish and that the kona jal and the short machine do. His one complaint about tourists was the polythene they leave behind.

COMMUNITY TESTIMONY | PROFESSIONAL KII

WHY WE ARE SHOWING YOU THIS

The question contained our conclusion. He declined it, twice, and gave a reason that was about his own household's cash rather than about the haor.

The CNRS informant, from a different position, said the opposite: that tourism has grown suddenly, that houseboats put pressure on the environment, and that local people are not receiving the livelihood benefit expected of it.

Both can be true. The benefit is real, immediate and small; the cost is diffuse, slower, and borne by a system rather than a household. That is a distribution problem across scale and across time, not a disagreement about facts.

Open question. Who is positioned to feel a cost that arrives a decade later?

What we would need before we used the word transition

THE COMPARISON WE MUST NOT MAKE

141 fish species in an earlier government assessment, against **68** in CNRS fish-catch monitoring about two months before we spoke.

That is not 73 extinctions. The two counts come from different methods, different monitoring windows and different scopes. A catch-monitoring exercise records what is landed, not what exists. We are reporting both numbers and refusing the subtraction.

The same discipline applies to the turtle nobody has seen for ten years, the dolphin remembered in the local rivers, and the birds that elders describe as once darkening the sky. These are memories, offered as memories. CNRS said plainly that no accessible, continuous species-level dataset exists for this place.

WHAT WOULD HAVE TO BE TRUE

— Income that holds through the nine months outside the lease window, for a named set of households, over more than one year.

— A fish stock measured the same way twice, far enough apart to show a direction.

— Entitlements that arrive: the card, the ban compensation, the allowance.

— A reason to expect the gear use to change, given that the users are local and expect to fish here next year.

— Someone accountable at the level where the driver sits, not only at the level where the damage shows.

PROFESSIONAL KII | OPEN QUESTION | OUR READING

Three futures the evidence allows, and who would have to act in each

If nothing changes at the level above

Silt keeps arriving from upstream in the monsoon. Depth keeps falling. The lease window keeps producing less from the same three months.

Who would have to act: anyone with reach upstream of the haor. Nobody we met had that reach.

If the local proposal is taken up

Participants asked for two things: deepen the beel, and put katha bamboo back as sanctuary. Their stated reason was so there would be more fish to catch.

Who would have to act: the departments that re-excavate, plus whoever decides what the sanctuary is for.

If tourism keeps growing unmanaged

Immediate cash for the villages with boats. Polythene, bank erosion and, on the CNRS account, pressure without the expected local benefit.

Who would have to act: investors described as based in Dhaka, and whoever sets a carrying capacity.

A tension inside the local proposal, which we are not resolving. The sanctuary is asked for so that more can be caught. The lecture on 8 November put the same shape in front of us with the rabbit and the carrots: plenty of food will not solve the problem, and plenty of food could be a problem. We are flagging the tension because it is theirs to settle, not ours.

COMMUNITY TESTIMONY · PROFESSIONAL KII · WORKSHOP LECTURE

Joypur 00:43:50-00:44:34 · CNRS KII Parts 01 and 02 · lecture 00:05:02

We can now ask for whom, at which level, and over how long

Four questions we can now ask better than we could on 6 November

For whom, and in which season?

The embankment protects the crop and is said to dry the fish out. Who gains in Chaitra, who loses, and does anyone hold both accounts at once when the decision is taken?

At which level does the fix belong?

If silt comes from Meghalaya and investment comes from Dhaka, what can a village society actually decide? Where is the mismatch between the scale of the problem and the scale of the response?

Why is the destructive gear local?

Participants named their neighbours, not outsiders, and disagreed about which gear destroys. What makes a gear worth using when the user expects to fish here again next year?

What would count as a transition?

We can describe coping in detail. We cannot say whether anything has shifted. What would we have to measure, and over how long, before we were entitled to use the word?

OPEN QUESTION

Each question names a level, a season or a person, rather than asking for a solution.

What changed in what we notice

Not conclusions. A different set of things we can now see, and a limit we accept.

We arrived looking for a problem in Tanguar Haor.
We leave looking for the level at which the problem is produced.

We arrived looking for outsiders damaging a commons.
We leave looking for why a local user chooses a gear he knows is contested.

We arrived looking for whether infrastructure exists.
We leave looking for whether it is used, by whom, in which month.

We arrived looking for signs of recovery.
We leave looking for what would have to be measured before recovery could be claimed.

> *"what you saw in Tanguar Haor, even if you go there for the next five years, what you will see is only one-third. Two-thirds you will never see."*
>
> Prof. Prateep Kumar Nayak, lecture, 8 November 2026, 00:18:20. Spoken in English; transcribed, not translated.

He also said that this is not a reason to walk away from the problem. It is a reason to stay engaged, to treat it as a process rather than a one-time fix, and to come back.

So we are not ending with what must be done. We are ending with a changed sense of what we are entitled to say after one day, and a list of the people we did not speak to: women in their own words, the tourist-board members, the fisheries and upazila officers, and anyone from the eighty-one other villages.

Thank you. We would rather be asked a hard question than a kind one.